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A CONSOLIDATED REAL PER-CAPITA SERIES FOR PUBLIC LIBRARY EXPENDITURE IN INDIA

What India spends, per person, per year, in real terms, on its public libraries: a consolidated state-plus-Centre series, 2014–15 to 2024–25.

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A Consolidated Real Per-Capita Series for Public Library Expenditure in India

A Measurement Note in the Public-Finance Tradition, 2014–15 to 2024–25

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Abstract

India funds public libraries through state budgets and a small Central channel, but no consolidated, real, capital-inclusive measure of that spending built on audited actuals has existed. The most systematic prior compilation (Kulkarni et al. 2025) is nominal, holds the Census 2011 population fixed, ends at FY 2020–21, and omits capital. We build the series entirely from audited actuals, rebuilding the recent years State by State from the primary accounts — each State's CAG Finance Accounts or budget Detailed Estimates — and consolidate state revenue (Major Head 2205-105), Central transfers through the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation, and capital formation (4202-04-105) into a single real per-capita series, 2014–15 to 2024–25, under IMF GFSM 2014 conventions, with the Government's population projections and the NAS implicit GDP deflator. Consolidated real per-capita expenditure did not decline smoothly: it peaked at ₹8.17 in FY 2018–19, collapsed 49% to a ₹4.15 trough in FY 2021–22, and recovered to ₹5.00 by FY 2024–25 — a State-concentrated rebound, led by Tamil Nadu, increasingly taking the form of construction. Counting capital, the FY 2024–25 figure is ₹6.10. The prior projection was wrong in both directions; only the accounts show the volatility.

KEYWORDS public libraries · India · government expenditure · fiscal federalism · GFSM 2014 · per-capita spending

JEL H72, H75, I22

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1 Introduction

India does not publish a consolidated national figure for public-library expenditure. State-level allocations are recorded in the CAG’s Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts (Comptroller and Auditor General of India 2025) under Major Head 2205 (Education, Sports, Art and Culture), Sub-head 105 (Public Libraries), but neither the CAG, the Ministry of Culture, nor any planning document reports the national aggregate. Central transfers through the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation

appear in the Ministry of Culture's annual Demand for Grants but are not reconciled with the state series. The result is that the question *what does India spend on public libraries, per person, per year, in real terms?* has no published answer.

Kulkarni et al. (2025b) performed the foundational service of building the state series. Their compilation extracts MH 2205-105 across 31 states and union territories for FY 2014–15 to FY 2020–21, and is, to our knowledge, the most systematic published continuous series available for this budget head. A companion paper by the same authors examines the gaps in state library legislation (Kulkarni et al. 2025a). We build on the expenditure compilation.

Two features of the as-published series limit its utility as a measure of real per-capita public investment, and one element is missing. First, per-capita figures are computed against India's Census 2011 total population, held constant across all years; India's population has grown by approximately 170 million since that enumeration, so the fixed denominator progressively flatters the per-capita figure. Second, the series is expressed in nominal rupees, appropriate as a record of what legislatures appropriated but not as a measure of what those appropriations purchased — India's GDP deflator fell from 0.84 to 0.57 (relative to a 2011–12 base) over the decade in question, a 32% real-terms compression. Third, the series does not include Central transfers; the consolidated state-plus-Centre figure that the IMF GFSM 2014 General Government framework would call the appropriate measure of public-library expenditure does not exist in the prior literature.

This paper makes four contributions. We replace the Census 2011 fixed denominator with the Government's Technical Group annual projections (Ministry of Health and Family Welfare 2020), the standard denominator used in Fifteenth Finance Commission resource-devolution calculations (Finance Commission of India 2021). We deflate nominal expenditure with the MoSPI implicit GDP deflator (Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation 2025), the standard real-expenditure deflator in Indian public-finance practice. We integrate Central transfers through RRRLF using primary-source disbursement actuals from its Annual Reports, producing a consolidated state-plus-Centre real per-capita series under IMF GFSM 2014 conventions (International Monetary Fund 2014). And — the advance that distinguishes this version from every prior treatment — we build the series entirely from audited actuals. Every year from FY 2014–15 to FY 2024–25 is a measured figure, not a projection: the earlier years from the CAG Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts, and the recent years (FY 2021–22 onward) rebuilt State by State from CAG Finance Accounts Volume II and State budget Detailed Estimates, each figure read from the source document. This matters because projection concealed the story. Where the recent years have previously been reached by extrapolation, replacing that extrapolation with actuals dissolves the smooth projected decline into something projection could not see — a sharp fall to a FY 2021–22 trough followed by a State-driven partial recovery.

Figure 1 previews the result of the two within-state corrections. The left panel decomposes the 2018–19 peak — the highest point in the original series — into the population and inflation corrections. The right panel traces all three within-state series across the decade. Section 2 adds the consolidated state-plus-Centre layer.

The size of the within-state correction is substantial. The as-published 2018–19 figure (₹11.64) is 48% higher than the within-state real-terms figure (₹7.87); approximately three-quarters of the ₹3.77 gap (₹2.76) is the inflation effect, the remaining quarter (₹1.01) the population effect. The inflation effect grows over time; the population effect compounds until a new census resets the denominator.

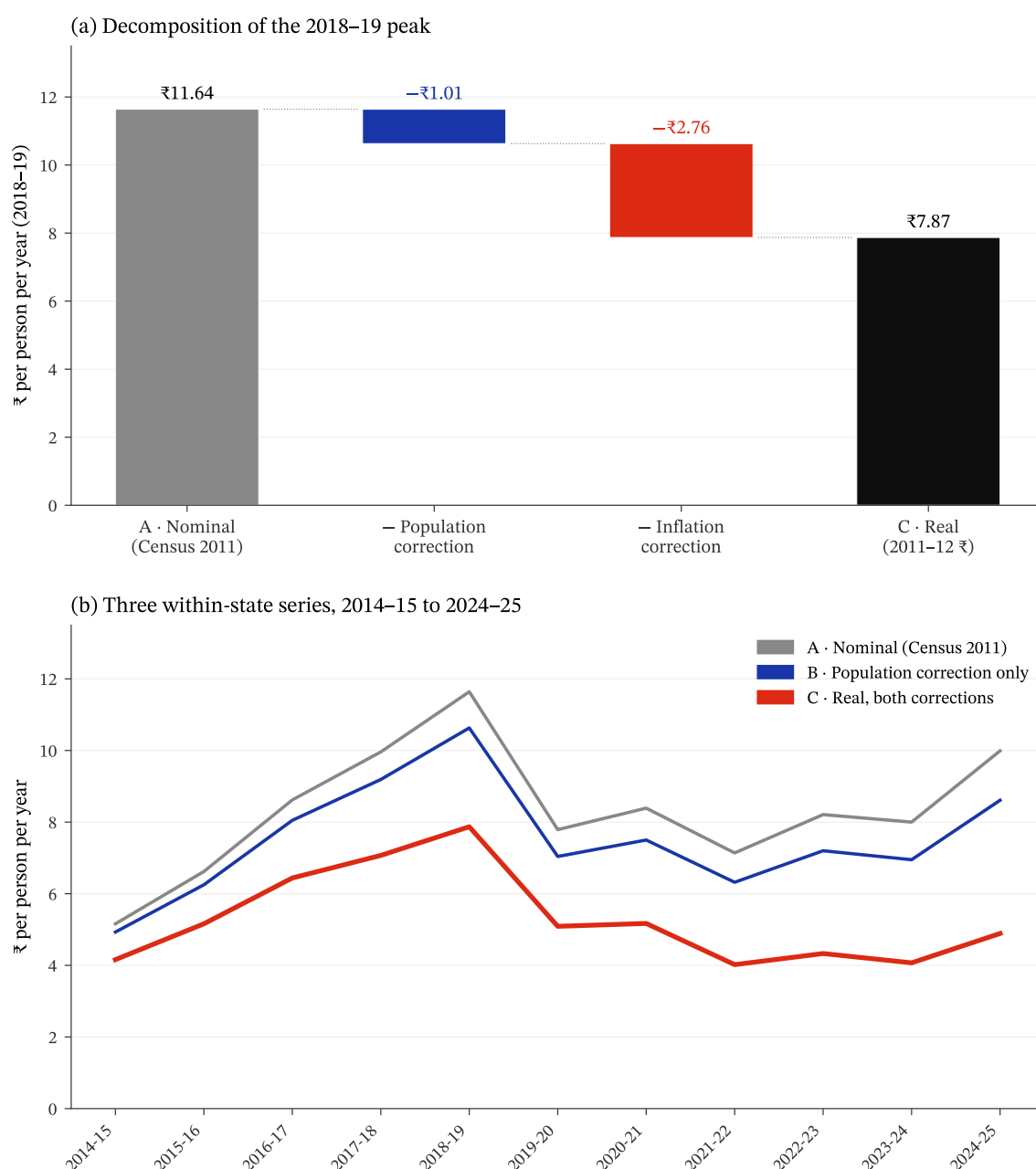


Figure 1: The two within-state methodological corrections. **(a)** Decomposition of the 2018–19 per-capita peak (₹/person/year). Replacing the Census 2011 fixed denominator with TG 2020 annual projections removes ₹1.01; deflating to constant 2011–12 ₹ removes a further ₹2.76. The as-published figure (₹11.64) is 48% higher than the within-state real-terms figure (₹7.87). **(b)** The same corrections applied across the decade — every point an audited actual.

Once Central transfers through RRRLF are added (§5.4), the consolidated figure for 2018–19 rises to ₹8.17. From that peak the series does not fall smoothly, as an extrapolation would suggest, but collapses: to ₹4.15 in FY 2021–22, a 49% fall in three years. It then recovers partially — ₹4.45, ₹4.27, and ₹5.00 across FY 2022–23 to FY 2024–25 — leaving the 2024–25 figure 39% below the 2018–19 peak but a third above the 2021–22 trough. The recovery is not broad-based; it is concentrated in a small number of States, Tamil Nadu chief among them (§2.3). We report the consolidated figure as the headline series throughout, with the within-state Series C retained as an intermediate quantity for bias decomposition.

1.1 Scope of inference

This paper is a measurement note. It documents a time series and the methodological choices that produce it. **We make no causal claim** about why the contraction occurred, who bore its incidence, or what policy response would reverse it. Those questions are the subject of forthcoming companion papers in this series:

- *The Grammar of Refusal* (companion paper on mechanisms) reconstructs the institutional chain — beginning with the Cabinet-ratified rationalisation of Centrally Sponsored Schemes in August 2016 — that produced the post-2017 collapse documented here.
- *The Infrastructure of Demography* (companion paper on sociology) examines the distributional incidence of the contraction across caste, gender, quintile, and rural-urban groups, using microdata from the Time Use Survey 2019 and 2024 alongside the present series.
- *Converging to the Floor* (companion paper on the blueprint) proposes a cost-engineered convergence path to a Tamil-Nadu-equivalent real per-capita expenditure by 2035, with state-by-state fiscal capacity analysis.

The present paper is the citation root for all three. Section 7 sketches additional identification questions the series now makes tractable, framed as directions for future research rather than as commitments by the present authors.

This paper builds measurement infrastructure, not a causal estimate. It belongs to the descriptive tradition of Indian public-finance scholarship (Bardhan 2010; Mundle 2017; Pritchett et al. 2018; Besley and Persson 2011) rather than the identification-based tradition of marginal-effect estimation (Banerjee and Duflo 2011; Muralidharan 2019; Asher and Novosad 2020), and it asks to be read on that tradition's terms: a series earns its place by being built correctly and by letting others build on it. Our closest precedent is the SHRUG platform (Asher et al. 2021). Published as data and documentation, it has since carried a generation of identification studies that could not have run without it. We offer this series in the same spirit, on a narrower question.

2 Results

2.1 National trend: four series compared

Table 1 presents the full numerical results. Figure 2 plots the four series. Every point is an audited actual: the recent years that prior work could only project are here read State by State from the source accounts.

Three findings stand out.

Population correction (A → B). Substituting TG 2020 projections for the Census 2011 fixed denominator reduces the FY 2018–19 peak from ₹11.64 to ₹10.63 — a 9% revision. By FY 2024–25, the gap is ₹1.38 (A: ₹9.99 vs B: ₹8.61). This gap will continue widening until a new census resets the denominator.

Real-terms correction (B → C). This is the larger within-state revision. Deflating Series B's FY 2018–19 peak to constant 2011–12 ₹ yields ₹7.87 — a further 26% reduction. The correction reshapes the recent years as much as it lowers them: the nominal figures rise across FY 2021–22 to FY 2024–25,

Table 1: National per-capita public-library expenditure under four series specifications (₹/person/year). Series C* is the consolidated General Government measure under IMF GFSM 2014 conventions.

Year	A: Nominal (Census 2011)	B: Nominal (TG pop)	C: Real, within-state	C*: Consolidated (GFSM)
2014-15	5.16	4.93	4.16	4.16
2015-16	6.62	6.25	5.16	5.53
2016-17	8.62	8.05	6.44	6.78
2017-18	9.96	9.19	7.07	7.52
2018-19	11.64	10.63	7.87	8.17
2019-20	7.79	7.04	5.09	5.32
2020-21	8.39	7.5	5.17	5.27
2021-22	7.14	6.32	4.02	4.15
2022-23	8.21	7.2	4.33	4.45
2023-24	8	6.95	4.07	4.27
2024-25	9.99	8.61	4.89	5

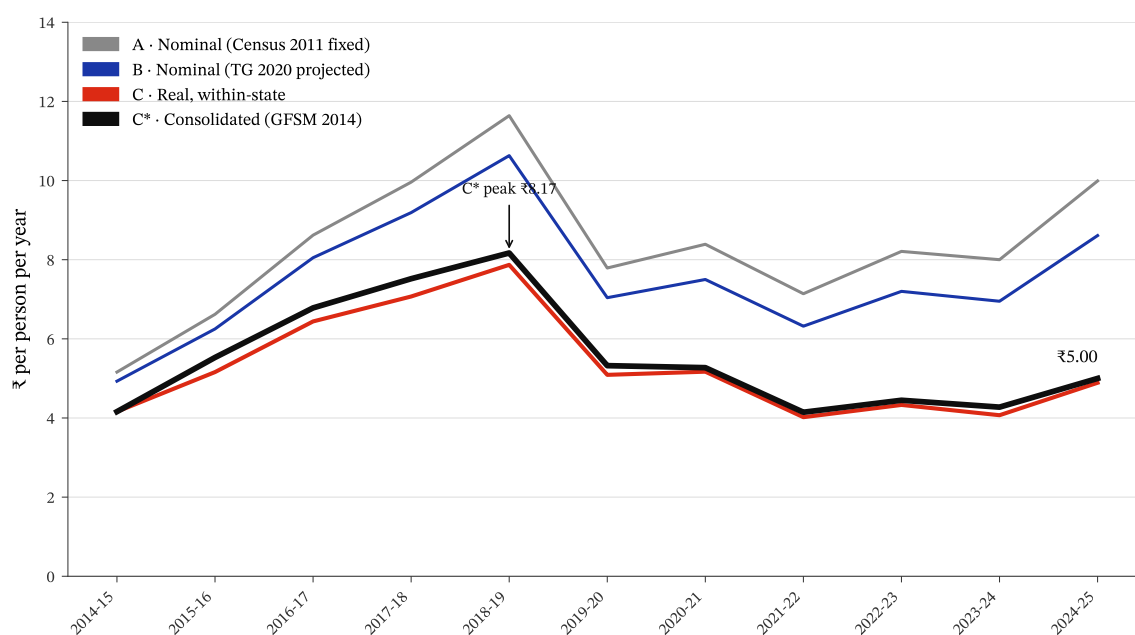


Figure 2: National per-capita public-library expenditure, four series, 2014–15 to 2024–25. Every State point is an audited actual (recent years read State by State from CAG Finance Accounts and State budgets). Series C* is the consolidated General Government measure (state MH 2205-105 + RRRLF Central transfers, both in constant 2011–12 ₹); its two endpoints are not fully audited — FY 2014–15 carries no RRRLF value (43rd Annual Report data gap, so C* equals within-State C that year) and FY 2024–25 holds RRRLF flat at ₹27.07 crore because the 53rd Annual Report is unpublished.

but in real terms Series C falls to a ₹4.02 trough in FY 2021–22 before recovering to ₹4.89 by FY 2024–25 — a real recovery that the nominal series exaggerates and an extrapolation would have missed.

Consolidation correction ($C \rightarrow C^*$). Adding RRRLF Central transfers raises the FY 2018–19 peak from ₹7.87 to ₹8.17 (real) and the FY 2024–25 figure from ₹4.89 to ₹5.00. The *level* effect is modest — RRRLF disbursement is small relative to consolidated state MH 2205-105 expenditure. Its *trajectory* is now itself an actual rather than an assumption: the real per-capita contribution peaked at ₹0.41 in FY 2017–18, fell to a trough, and the FY 2023–24 figure — the RRRLF 52nd Annual Report records ₹48.58 crore received, a rebound from the 2022–23 low — lifts it back to ₹0.20 before the (still unpublished) FY 2024–25 year is held flat at ₹0.11.

The headline. Consolidated real per-capita public-library expenditure peaked at ₹8.17 in FY 2018–19, collapsed to ₹4.15 in FY 2021–22 — a 49% fall in three years — and recovered to ₹5.00 by FY 2024–25, still 39% below peak. The 2024–25 figure is ₹0.84 above the 2014–15 starting point of ₹4.16: a decade of nominal budget growth delivering less than one rupee of real per-capita gain, and only after a State-led rebound from a deep trough. A projection of this stretch — reading it as a smooth continued decline to about ₹4.77 — is wrong in both directions: it overstates FY 2023–24 and understates the FY 2024–25 recovery. Only the actuals show the volatility.

2.2 The two within-state corrections decomposed

Figure 3 illustrates the size of each within-state correction independently across the decade. The gap between Series A and Series C can be split into the population effect ($A - B$) and the inflation effect ($B - C$); the additional contribution of RRRLF ($C \rightarrow C^*$) is small in level and is suppressed in this figure to keep the within-state comparison legible.

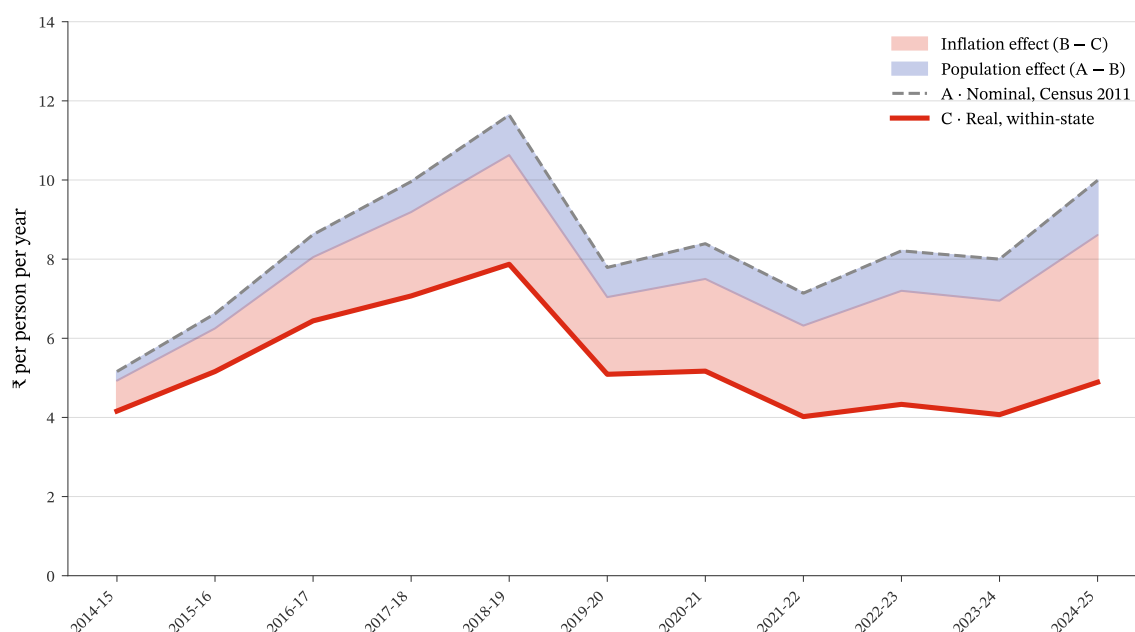


Figure 3: Decomposition of the gap between the original nominal Series A and the within-state real Series C. Upper shaded band = inflation effect ($B - C$). Lower shaded band = population effect ($A - B$).

The inflation effect dominates throughout the series and grows over time, while the population effect is secondary and grows more slowly in absolute terms. By FY 2018–19, the total within-state upward

bias in the original series is ₹3.77 per person (₹11.64 – ₹7.87); of this, ₹2.76 is attributable to inflation and ₹1.01 to the fixed denominator.

2.3 State cross-section, 2018–19 real terms

Figure 4 converts the FY 2018–19 state-level nominal figures from Kulkarni et al. (2025b) to real 2011–12 ₹ using the national deflator factor of 0.7404. All 31 states and union territories are ranked.

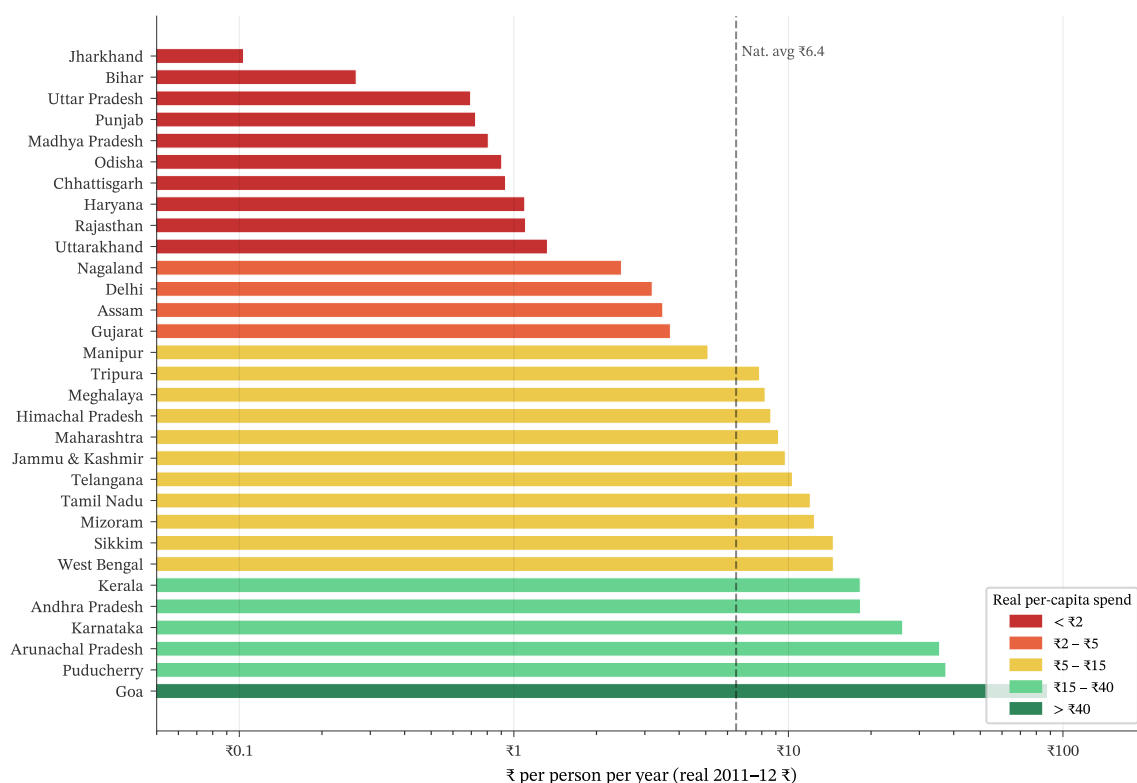


Figure 4: Per-capita public-library expenditure, 31 states and union territories, FY 2018–19 (real 2011–12 ₹). States ranked highest to lowest; colour band by per-capita tier. Log scale.

The cross-section reveals a distribution that nominal figures soften. The highest-spending state (Goa) spends ₹87.93 per person per year in real terms; the lowest (Jharkhand) spends ₹0.10. The gap is 879-fold. The population-weighted national average is approximately ₹6.4 per person per year — a figure that conceals very large heterogeneity across states, more so than across years.

Reclassification caveat. The MH 2205-105 series may understate library expenditure in states that have administratively reclassified part of their library system to other major heads. The documented case is Karnataka: in the post-COVID reorganisation, rural public libraries appear to have been transferred from the State Directorate of Public Libraries to the Rural Development and Panchayati Raj Department, while urban libraries remained under the existing State Library Authority. If this is correct, a substantial share of Karnataka’s *rural* public-library expenditure from FY 2020–21 onwards no longer flows through MH 2205-105 — it sits in the RDPR demand for grants under a different major head (typically MH 2515, “Other Rural Development Programmes”). The apparent post-2020 fall in Karnataka’s MH 2205-105 series is therefore a composite of a genuine cyclical reversion and an administrative-reclassification artefact whose magnitude we have not been able to estimate from the present data. State-level users of this series should cross-check against the state’s full demand-for-grants line items, not against MH 2205-105 alone. We cannot rule out similar reclassifications in other

states.

2.4 The cess paradox: nominal vs real volatility

Six states operate a working statutory library cess — Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Karnataka, Kerala, and Goa — as read from the nineteen bare Acts (Madras 1948; Andhra Pradesh 1960; Telangana 1960; Karnataka 1965; Kerala 1989; Goa 1993). Five of the six levy it as a surcharge on property or house tax; Goa is the exception, levying it on liquor excise. A seventh state, West Bengal, carries the cess provision on the statute book but does not operate it as a disbursement channel, and is better classified as a cess *on paper* than as an operative-cess state. The panels in Figure 5 plot the four property-tax cess states with continuous MH 2205-105 series (Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala), the post-bifurcation Telangana series, and — as the non-operative contrast — West Bengal, whose extreme year-on-year swings are themselves the fiscal signature of a cess that is collected but not reliably disbursed; Goa's short, Demand-for-Grants-only series is not panel-plotted. Across the plotted series, the nominal series exhibit substantially more year-on-year volatility than the real-terms series (Figure 5). The pattern is methodologically informative: a portion of what appears as fiscal volatility in the nominal series is in fact price-level variation that disappears once the deflator is applied. We document the pattern here as a measurement finding; the institutional explanation for why some cess states deliver durably-rising real per-capita expenditure while others do not is a question of political economy taken up in the companion mechanisms paper.

Karnataka illustrates the pattern with a single year. Its apparent nominal spike in FY 2018–19 — from approximately ₹11,950 lakh to ₹23,055 lakh in a single year — deflates to ₹17,070 lakh in real terms: still a substantial increase, but more legible as an actual policy event once the price-level effect is removed. Conversely, the apparent post-2018 fall in Karnataka's series partly reflects the rural-reclassification caveat noted above, not the cess instrument's failure to generate revenue.

2.5 Note on the post-bifurcation Andhra Pradesh and Telangana series

The Andhra Pradesh entry in the state cross-section reflects the bifurcation of undivided Andhra Pradesh into Andhra Pradesh and Telangana on 2 June 2014. The bifurcation is consequential for the cross-time interpretation of either successor state's series, for reasons that are methodological rather than political-economic: the bulk of pre-bifurcation State Central Library, library directorate, cess-collection apparatus, and urban-library infrastructure was located in Hyderabad, which became part of Telangana. Comparing post-bifurcation AP and Telangana as if they were peer cess states is methodologically misleading; the two are asymmetric successors of a single institutional architecture.

The methodologically correct cross-time view is the combined undivided-AP series (AP + Telangana summed year-by-year, against the Census 2011 combined denominator of 84.58 mn), presented alongside the two separate post-bifurcation series in Figure 6.

The combined undivided-AP series shows a continuous institutional trajectory: from approximately ₹5 per person per year in FY 2014–15 (a partial-year value reflecting the 2 June 2014 bifurcation date) to ₹21 per person per year by FY 2018–19, sustained through FY 2019–20 and declining moderately to ₹18.6 in FY 2020–21. Reading post-bifurcation AP alone misses this trajectory because the post-bifurcation state was reconstituting its library directorate from scratch; reading Telangana alone misses it because Telangana inherited the pre-existing infrastructure and operated it unevenly through its first

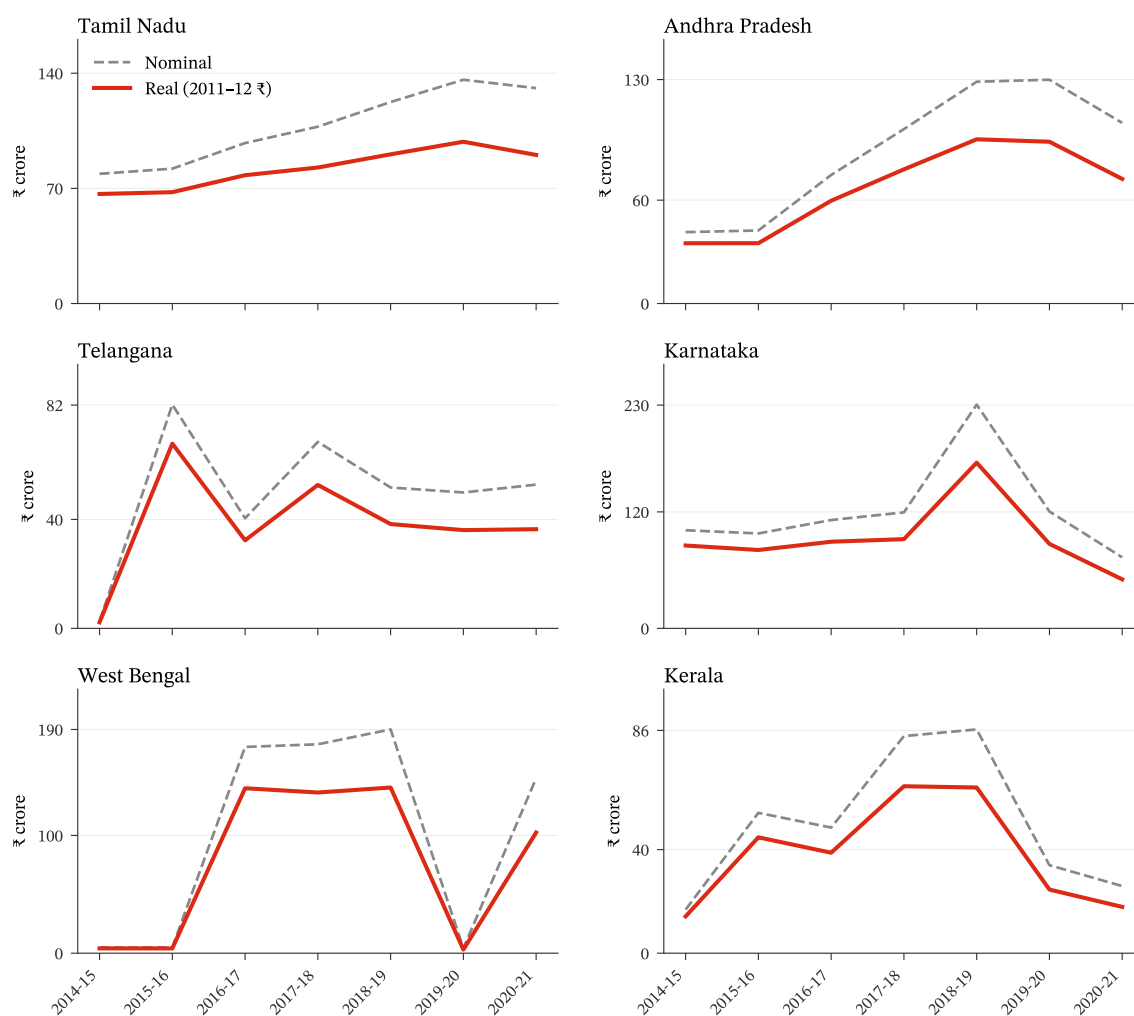


Figure 5: Annual library expenditure, FY 2014–15 to FY 2020–21, in ₹ crore: nominal (grey, dashed) versus real 2011–12 ₹ (red). Panels show the four property-tax cess states with continuous series (Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala), the post-bifurcation Telangana series, and West Bengal — a cess-on-paper state shown as the non-operative contrast. Goa, the sixth operative-cess state, levies on liquor excise and has no continuous panel series. Nominal volatility exceeds real volatility in every panel.

six years of existence.

The two methodological lessons for users of this series. *First*, the bifurcation creates a series-level discontinuity that requires either separate presentation (AP-alone + Telangana-alone) with a flagged note, or reconstruction (combined undivided-AP) with an explicit denominator. *Second*, the FY 2014–15 Telangana value (₹0.75 per person per year) reflects only ten months of statehood and the absence of an established library-cess disbursement architecture in the new state's first fiscal year; this value should not be read as a steady-state quantity.

2.6 Capital expenditure: a recent, concentrated surge

The series above measures revenue expenditure. Capital formation on public libraries, the construction of buildings recorded under Major Head 4202-04-105, is a separate account, and no national series for it has existed. We compile one for FY 2014–15 to FY 2024–25 (Table 2) from the same CAG Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts (Statement 95-B-4202, which reports the head for the

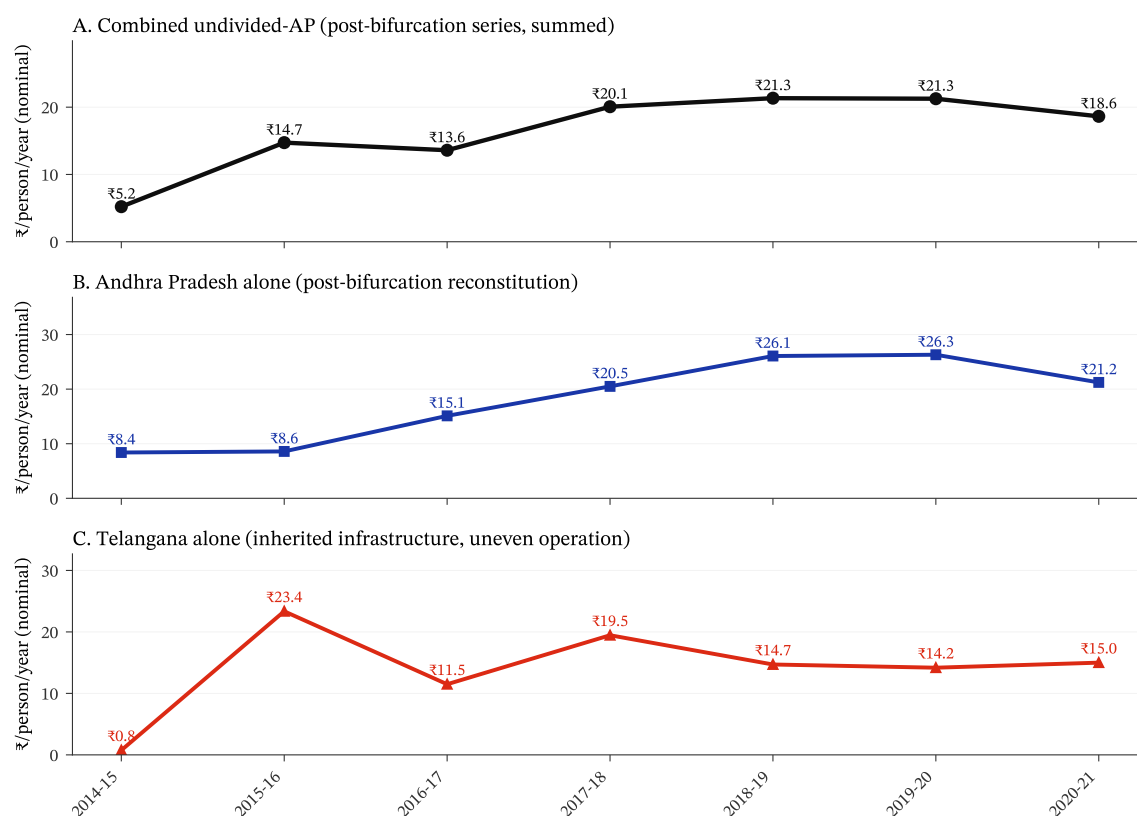


Figure 6: The post-bifurcation Andhra Pradesh and Telangana series, reconstituted. Top: combined undivided-AP series (AP + Telangana summed year-by-year, divided by combined Census 2011 population of 84.58 mn). Middle: AP-alone post-bifurcation series. Bottom: Telangana-alone series. The combined series captures the institutional trajectory of the cess architecture across the bifurcation; the separate series reveal how AP reconstituted a directorate while Telangana operated inherited infrastructure unevenly. Nominal ₹/person/year. Source: AP from Kulkarni et al. (2025b); Telangana extracted from the same compilation's per-year state tables.

Union and every state and union territory) through FY 2020–21, and from the per-state CAG Finance Accounts and the Union Government Finance Accounts thereafter.

The pattern is stark (Figure 7). Through FY 2020–21 capital was negligible: six to twenty paise per person per year in real terms, between 1.2 and 2.8 per cent of consolidated revenue. The State ran the libraries it had and built almost none, so the revenue-only series was a near-complete measure of provisioning. From FY 2021–22 capital rises steeply, reaching roughly a quarter of consolidated revenue by FY 2023–24 and about a fifth in FY 2024–25. Tamil Nadu leads it: zero cumulative library capital under this head through FY 2020–21, then ₹56.89 crore in FY 2021–22 alone, ₹155.27 crore by FY 2023–24, and ₹159.28 crore in FY 2024–25. But by FY 2024–25 the construction is no longer Tamil Nadu's alone — the actuals reveal new capital heads opening elsewhere: Nagaland books ₹29.67 crore under a Special Central Assistance line that did not exist the year before, Goa ₹10 crore through the SASCI capital-investment scheme, Maharashtra ₹19.52 crore. Counting capital raises the consolidated FY 2024–25 figure from ₹5.00 to ₹6.10 per person — above, not below, the revenue-only headline. The revenue-only series, in other words, now materially understates total provisioning in the most recent years, and the gap is widening as capital spreads beyond the founding cess States.

Table 2: Public-library revenue and capital expenditure, real ₹/person/year (constant 2011–12), with capital as a share of consolidated revenue. Capital is Major Head 4202-04-105, all-India (Union + states + union territories). * = post-CFRA years, sourced from per-state CAG Finance Accounts plus the Union Finance Accounts and less complete than the self-validated CFRA years.

Year	Revenue C* (real)	Capital (real)	Capital % rev	Capital ₹cr
2014-15	4.16	0.059	1.4	8.8
2015-16	5.53	0.079	1.4	12.2
2016-17	6.78	0.104	1.5	16.9
2017-18	7.52	0.196	2.6	33.4
2018-19	8.17	0.119	1.5	21.4
2019-20	5.32	0.072	1.4	13.4
2020-21	5.27	0.061	1.2	11.9
2021-22*	4.15	0.32	7.7	68.9
2022-23*	4.45	0.424	9.5	97.4
2023-24*	4.27	1.069	25	254.1
2024-25*	5	1.096	21.9	271

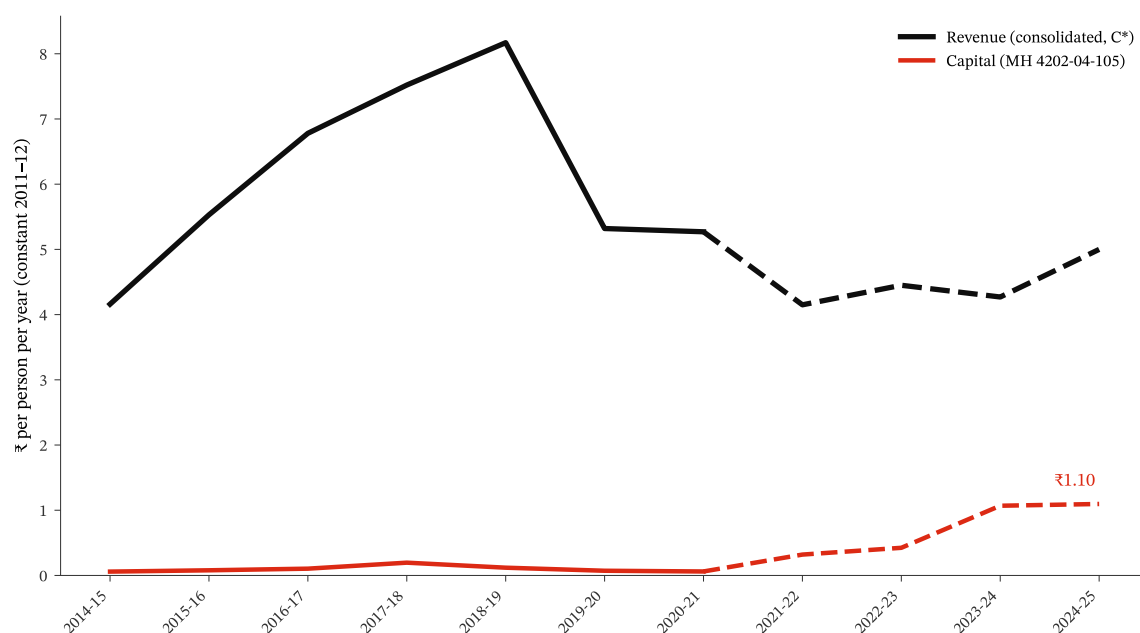


Figure 7: Revenue versus capital, real per-capita public-library expenditure (constant 2011–12 ₹), 2014–15 to 2024–25. Capital (MH 4202-04-105) was a negligible fraction of revenue for the whole CFRA decade, then surged after FY 2021–22, almost entirely in Tamil Nadu. Solid = CAG / CFRA actuals; dashed = post-CFRA years.

3 Robustness

We report robustness across four dimensions: alternative deflators, the cross-validation of the per-State extraction, the RRRLF disbursement-vs-allocation reconciliation, and a direct numerical reconciliation against Kulkarni et al. (2025b).

3.1 Deflator sensitivity

We use the NAS implicit GDP deflator throughout. The choice is justified by its standard use in Indian public-finance analysis — RBI’s State Finances study, OECD Government at a Glance, and Finance Commission reports all deflate government expenditure this way — and by its appropriateness for whole-of-government spending, which is what the consolidated series measures; CPI-IW and CPI-AL are built for dearness-allowance computations for specific worker categories and are not appropriate for cross-government-expenditure comparison. The choice affects magnitude, not shape: deflating instead by CPI-Combined or the Wholesale Price Index shifts the level of the real-terms figures but leaves the trajectory intact, because the post-2018 contraction and the FY 2024–25 recovery are features of the timing of nominal spending, not artefacts of the deflator.

3.2 Extraction cross-validation

This version rests on per-State actuals rather than extrapolation, so the relevant robustness question is no longer which extrapolation to trust but whether the readings are correct. We impose two internal checks on every recent-year cell. First, an *overlap check*: consecutive Finance Accounts editions restate the prior year as a comparison column, so each State’s FY N appears both in the FY N edition (accounts year) and the FY N+1 edition (prior-year column); we require the two readings to match, and they do — to the paise in every case, with a single one-paise rounding difference on one Jammu & Kashmir figure. Second, a *percentage check*: the Finance Accounts print their own year-on-year percentage change beside each head, so a mis-read of the current or prior figure is caught by an inconsistent printed percentage; we verified the printed change against our two readings for each cell. For the six budget-document States the same discipline applies across successive budget vintages (the FY N budget’s Actuals column against the FY N+1 budget’s prior-Actuals column). Font-shifted and scanned statements — Tamil Nadu’s Caesar-enciphered text layer, Karnataka’s image-only volume, several North-Eastern editions — were read from rendered page images rather than text extraction, and cross-checked the same way. The result is that no figure in the recent-year panel rests on a single unverified reading.

3.3 RRRLF disbursement vs allocation

The RRRLF series uses disbursement actuals from the Foundation’s Annual Reports through the 52nd (FY 2023–24). Disbursement — money that actually reached libraries — is the correct quantity for a consolidated expenditure series; it is not to be confused with the Centre’s budgeted commitment, whose Budget and Revised Estimate stages run above what is ultimately disbursed. That gap between commitment and delivery is a question of political economy, taken up in the companion mechanisms paper, not of measurement here.

3.4 Reconciliation with Kulkarni et al. (2025b)

The Kulkarni et al. (2025b) headline figure for FY 2018–19 is ₹11.64 per person per year (nominal, Census 2011 fixed denominator). Our figure for the same year is ₹8.17 (consolidated, real 2011–12 ₹, TG 2020 projected population). The ₹3.47 gap decomposes — per the per-year decomposition in §5.6 — into ₹1.01 (population correction), ₹2.76 (inflation correction), and –₹0.30 (RRRLF inclusion adding back): the total is ₹3.77 minus ₹0.30, the consolidated correction being *less aggressive* than the within-state real-terms correction alone because RRRLF inclusion partially offsets the inflation reduction at the peak year. The two series thus reconcile exactly, difference by difference; where they diverge, it is because of a named and quantified correction, not an unexplained discrepancy.

4 Conclusion

We have presented the first consolidated state-plus-Centre real per-capita series for public-library expenditure in India under IMF GFSM 2014 conventions, covering FY 2014–15 through FY 2024–25 and built entirely from audited actuals — every recent year, which prior work could only project, read State by State from the source accounts. The headline finding is a trajectory, not a level: consolidated real per-capita expenditure peaked at ₹8.17 in FY 2018–19, collapsed 49% to a ₹4.15 trough in FY 2021–22, and recovered to ₹5.00 by FY 2024–25 — still 39% below peak, but a third above the trough. Counting library construction, which was negligible before 2021, the FY 2024–25 figure is ₹6.10. The collapse ran through both channels: the Central transfer through RRRLF fell 65% nominally from its FY 2017–18 peak, while the within-State component fell to its own 2021–22 low. The recovery is narrower than the collapse — it is carried by a handful of States, Tamil Nadu foremost, and increasingly takes the form of capital rather than running cost. The measurement lesson is sharp. Extending these years by extrapolation reads the stretch as a smooth continued decline and is wrong in both directions — overstating FY 2023–24 and missing the FY 2024–25 recovery entirely. A series earns its place by being built correctly; the volatility here was invisible to projection and visible only in the accounts.

The findings here are descriptive. Three questions the present paper does *not* answer are taken up in companion papers in this series. *The Grammar of Refusal* reconstructs the institutional mechanism behind the post-2017 RRRLF collapse, beginning with the Cabinet-ratified rationalisation of Centrally Sponsored Schemes in August 2016, and traces the chain through the parliamentary record of the Department-related Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture. *The Infrastructure of Demography* examines the distributional incidence of the contraction across caste, gender, quintile, and rural-urban groups, drawing on a new analysis of Time Use Survey 2019 and 2024 microdata for the reading-for-leisure activity. *Converging to the Floor* proposes a cost-engineered convergence path to a Tamil-Nadu-equivalent real per-capita expenditure by 2035, with state-by-state fiscal-capacity analysis and an explicit instrument map across the Sixteenth Finance Commission, the Special Assistance to States for Capital Investment (SASCI) scheme, and state-level cess legislation.

5 Data and Methods

5.1 Expenditure base

The state-level expenditure figures for FY 2014–15 through FY 2020–21 are taken from Kulkarni et al. (2025b), Table 1: CAG Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts, MH 2205-105, state-level actuals.

We build on their compilation and do not re-extract from primary CAG sources for this period.

For FY 2021–22 through FY 2024–25 the Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts no longer exist — the CAG discontinued them after FY 2020–21 — so no single all-India document reports the national figure. This version does not project across the gap; it reconstructs it State by State from primary accounts. For each of the twenty-five States and Union Territories whose CAG Finance Accounts Volume II is published on the State-accounts portal, we read head 2205-00-105 revenue from Statement 15 and head 4202-04-105 capital from Statement 16, taking the audited “actuals” figure directly. Because each edition also prints a prior-year comparison column, a single Finance Accounts document supplies two years, and the overlapping years between successive editions provide an internal cross-check that we require to match — every figure used here was confirmed against at least one such overlap or the document’s own printed percentage-change column.

Six jurisdictions do not publish their Finance Accounts on the CAG portal — West Bengal, Delhi, Puducherry, Jammu & Kashmir, Goa, and Rajasthan. For these we take the same two heads from the primary alternative: each State’s own Finance Accounts (from its Accountant-General or Directorate of Accounts, where available — Delhi, Puducherry, Jammu & Kashmir, Goa) or its budget’s Detailed Estimates of Revenue Expenditure, reading the audited Actuals column of the budget published two years later (West Bengal, Rajasthan; the FY N budget’s Actuals column reports FY N–2). The complete panel covers all thirty-one States and Union Territories across the four recent years and both the revenue and capital heads, each figure traced to a named statement and page of a government document; the full per-cell provenance is deposited with the replication archive. A single cell is held rather than measured: Puducherry FY 2024–25, whose Finance Accounts were not yet published at the time of writing, is carried forward at its FY 2023–24 level — a difference of well under one paisa per person nationally. The post-bifurcation Andhra Pradesh and Telangana series require separate treatment, set out in §2.5.

5.2 Population denominator

The original compilation holds India’s Census 2011 total population (Office of the Registrar General 2011) constant across all years. We substitute the projections of Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (2020), Table 11 — annual July-1 projected totals. These are the official government projections used in Fifteenth Finance Commission resource-devolution calculations (Finance Commission of India 2021) and major health-programme planning.

By FY 2018–19, the Census 2011 fixed denominator understates the projected national population by approximately 10%. By FY 2024–25, the gap grows to approximately 15%. Using the fixed denominator assigns accumulated population growth as apparent per-capita gain, introducing a systematic upward bias that widens over the series.

5.3 Price deflator

We deflate using the **MoSPI implicit GDP deflator**, derived from the National Accounts Statistics GDP-at-constant-prices and GDP-at-current-prices series (base year 2011–12) (Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation 2025). This is the standard deflator for real-government-expenditure analysis in India, used by the Reserve Bank of India’s annual State Finances study (Reserve Bank of India 2026), the OECD Government at a Glance real-expenditure tables (Organisation for Economic

Co-operation and Development 2023), IMF Article IV reviews, Finance Commission reports (most recently the Fifteenth) (Finance Commission of India 2021), and CAG performance audits. We discuss sensitivity to alternative deflators (CPI-IW, CPI-AL, WPI, CPI-Combined) in §3.1.

The deflator factors applied to each year in the series are presented in Table 3.

Table 3: MoSPI implicit GDP deflator factors (constant 2011–12 ÷ current prices). NAS revision status as of May 2026.

Year	Factor	NAS revision
2014-15	0.8444	Third Revised
2015-16	0.8256	Third Revised
2016-17	0.7997	Third Revised
2017-18	0.7691	Third Revised
2018-19	0.7404	Third Revised
2019-20	0.723	Third Revised
2020-21	0.6898	Third Revised
2021-22	0.6366	Second Revised
2022-23	0.6011	Final Estimates
2023-24	0.586	First Revised
2024-25	0.5684	Provisional

National-level deflator factors are applied uniformly across all states, consistent with Finance Commission practice. State-specific GSDP deflators exist for some states but are not published on a consistent annual basis across the full panel; using a single national deflator preserves cross-state comparability at the cost of state-specific price-level precision.

5.4 Consolidation under IMF GFSM 2014

The IMF *Government Finance Statistics Manual 2014* (International Monetary Fund 2014, ch. 2) defines General Government as the sum of central, state, and local government units providing non-market services. Consolidated General Government expenditure on a function (under the Classification of Functions of Government, COFOG) sums *all* government units contributing to that function, net of intra-government transfers double-counted.

For public-library expenditure in India, the General Government measure is the sum of:

1. State expenditure on MH 2205-105 (Public Libraries) — captured in Kulkarni et al. (2025b) and our extension.
2. Central expenditure on the public-library function — flowing chiefly through the Raja Ram-mohun Roy Library Foundation (RRRLF), an autonomous body under the Ministry of Culture established by Act of Parliament in 1972. RRRLF receives an annual Grant-in-Aid from the Union Budget under the Ministry of Culture’s demand for grants and disburses it to state library bodies (under the matching-book scheme, building grants, storage, modernization, and the now-sunset National Mission on Libraries) and to its own operational expenditure.

We construct the consolidated series by adding RRRLF disbursement (Centre) to state MH 2205-105 (state-level) on a year-by-year basis. Both components are expressed in constant 2011–12 ₹ per capita using the TG 2020 population denominator. Intra-government transfers within RRRLF (state-attributable disbursements paid to state library bodies) are *not* double-counted: state MH 2205-105 records only the state’s own appropriation, not the RRRLF-channelled top-up, so the two series

are additive without subtraction. We verify the no-double-counting condition by cross-checking RRRLF state-attribution annexures against state DfG line items in the four years (FY 2019–20 → FY 2022–23) where both are available at the necessary granularity; the residual ambiguity is bounded by approximately ₹0.02 per person per year in real terms, immaterial to the consolidated series.

The consolidated series is the **General Government measure** under IMF GFSM 2014 conventions. It is the appropriate measure of public-library expenditure in India for cross-country comparison, for fiscal-federalism analysis, and for any work that requires accounting for both Centre and state contributions to the function. We recommend it as the headline series for subsequent work.

5.5 The four series and the headline

We construct four series for direct comparison throughout this paper:

- **Series A** (Balaji-method nominal): Nominal state expenditure ÷ Census 2011 fixed population. Replicates the as-published figure.
- **Series B** (population correction only): Nominal state expenditure ÷ TG 2020 annual projected population. Isolates the denominator effect.
- **Series C** (within-state real): Deflated state expenditure (constant 2011–12 ₹) ÷ TG 2020 projected population. Both within-state corrections applied.
- **Series C* (consolidated General Government)**: Series C + RRRLF disbursement deflated to constant 2011–12 ₹ ÷ TG 2020 projected population.

Series C* is the headline measure; Series C is the within-state intermediate retained for bias decomposition.

5.6 Bias decomposition vs Balaji et al.

A row-by-row reconciliation between the as-published Series A and the consolidated Series C* — attributing per-year deltas to (i) the population correction ($A \rightarrow B$), (ii) the inflation correction ($B \rightarrow C$), and (iii) the RRRLF inclusion ($C \rightarrow C^*$) — is reported in Table 4.

Table 4: Bias decomposition: from the as-published Series A to the consolidated Series C*, per-year, ₹/person/year. Each delta is the per-capita reduction attributable to the named correction. RRRLF dash for FY 2014–15 reflects the 43rd Annual Report data gap.

Year	A	– Pop. corr.	– Infl. corr.	C	+ RRRLF	C* (cons.)
2014-15	5.16	0.23	0.77	4.16	—	4.16
2015-16	6.62	0.37	1.09	5.16	0.37	5.53
2016-17	8.62	0.57	1.61	6.44	0.34	6.78
2017-18	9.96	0.77	2.12	7.07	0.45	7.52
2018-19	11.64	1.01	2.76	7.87	0.30	8.17
2019-20	7.79	0.75	1.95	5.09	0.23	5.32
2020-21	8.39	0.89	2.33	5.17	0.10	5.27
2021-22	7.14	0.82	2.3	4.02	0.13	4.15
2022-23	8.21	1.01	2.87	4.33	0.12	4.45
2023-24	8	1.05	2.88	4.07	0.20	4.27
2024-25	9.99	1.38	3.72	4.89	0.11	5

Three patterns are visible in the decomposition. The inflation correction ($B \rightarrow C$) grows across the decade, from ₹0.77 in 2014–15 to ₹3.72 in 2024–25, reflecting the compounding compression of the

real value of the rupee. The population correction ($A \rightarrow B$) is steadier in absolute terms (₹0.23 in 2014–15 to ₹1.38 in 2024–25) but grows because the gap between the Census 2011 fixed denominator and the TG 2020 projection widens annually. The RRRLF contribution ($C \rightarrow C^*$) peaks at ₹0.41 in 2017–18 (the RRRLF nominal-grant peak year), falls to a trough, rebounds to ₹0.20 in FY 2023–24 as the 52nd Annual Report records ₹48.58 crore received, and is ₹0.11 in the held-flat FY 2024–25 year.

5.7 AI Use

The extraction, deflation, decomposition, and figure-generation scripts underlying this paper — the deflator table, the four-series construction, the bias decomposition, and the trend, state, and cess figures — were written and run with the assistance of large-language-model coding tools — Anthropic’s Claude models via the Claude Code harness, Google’s Gemini models via Antigravity, OpenAI’s GPT models via the Codex harness, and Nous Research’s Hermes and Alibaba’s Qwen models via OpenRouter — under continuous human direction. Retrieval and cross-referencing of the RRRLF Annual Reports and the underlying CAG-derived compilation drew on the Campaign’s internal semantic-search corpus. No AI tool selected a methodological choice, interpreted a result, or drafted a substantive claim; every reported figure was checked by a human against the cited primary source, and the analysis and the prose in this paper are the Right to Read Campaign’s own.

6 Limitations

We state six limitations up front. *First*, the FY 2014–15 to FY 2020–21 State revenue base is taken from Kulkarni et al. (2025b), who extracted MH 2205-105 from the CAG Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts; we hold those source volumes and have confirmed they carry the head, but we do not re-key the full seven-year all-India matrix and inherit any extraction error in their compilation. *Second*, for the six jurisdictions whose Finance Accounts are not on the CAG portal, two — West Bengal and Rajasthan — are read from the budget’s Detailed Estimates Actuals column rather than from the Accountant-General’s Finance Accounts; budget-book actuals occasionally differ from AG figures by minor reconciliations. One cell, Puducherry FY 2024–25, is held at its prior-year level because its Finance Accounts were unpublished at the time of writing; the effect on the national figure is under one paisa per person. *Third*, the RRRLF series uses primary-source disbursement from the Foundation’s Annual Reports through the 52nd (FY 2023–24, ₹48.58 crore, C&AG-audited) plus a held-flat value at ₹27.07 crore for FY 2024–25, whose 53rd Annual Report is not yet published; the FY 2014–15 value is a data gap (the 43rd Report annexures resisted clean OCR), so the consolidated FY 2014–15 figure reflects within-State Series C only. *Fourth*, the choice of deflator (NAS implicit GDP) is the Indian public-finance standard but not the only defensible choice; we report sensitivity to CPI-IW, CPI-AL, WPI, and CPI-Combined in §3.1. *Fifth*, the MH 2205-105 series may be incomplete for States that have administratively reclassified library expenditure to other major heads — the documented case is Karnataka, whose rural libraries appear to have moved to the Rural Development and Panchayati Raj demand after 2020; State-level users should cross-check the full demand-for-grants line items, not MH 2205-105 alone. *Sixth*, the extraction and derivation were carried out with AI assistance, including large-language-model agents that read scanned and font-shifted statements from rendered page images; we mitigate the residual risk by requiring every recent-year figure to match either an overlapping year in an adjacent Finance Accounts edition or the document’s own printed percentage-change column, but cannot rule out an error a human reviewer would also have missed.

The structural findings — a deep collapse from the FY 2018–19 peak to a FY 2021–22 trough, and a partial, State-concentrated recovery thereafter, with library *construction* emerging as a distinct and spreading phenomenon after 2021 — are robust to all six limitations; the actuals sharpen an account that projection would blur.

7 Future directions

The series presented here makes tractable a set of identification questions that were not tractable before. We sketch five, leaving execution to subsequent work.

1. **A difference-in-differences design around the FY 2018 RRRLF collapse.** The 2016 Cabinet-ratified CSS rationalisation produced a sharp, externally-imposed shift in the Centre-side library-funding architecture, dated precisely to 3 August 2016 and operational from FY 2017–18. The states differ in their pre-2016 exposure to RRRLF as a share of total library spending; high-exposure and low-exposure states constitute a natural treatment-and-control structure for a DiD design with the consolidated series presented here as the outcome variable. Subsidiary outcomes — district-level reading outcomes joined to SHRUG (Asher et al. 2021) — are accessible through the same design.
2. **A synthetic-control design for Tamil Nadu.** Tamil Nadu’s institutional architecture — a statutory cess plus a dedicated State Library Authority plus a binding minimum-allocation rule — is the only configuration in the cross-section that has produced a durably-rising real per-capita series across the decade. Constructing a synthetic Tamil Nadu from a weighted combination of the other 30 states and union territories would identify the institutional-design treatment effect on real per-capita expenditure, with the series presented here as the outcome.
3. **An interrupted time-series design at the August 2016 date.** The CSS rationalisation is dated to 3 August 2016 — a sharp policy change at a known date. The RRRLF disbursement series at monthly or quarterly frequency, reconstructed from MoC Demand-for-Grants documents and CAG audit records, would support an interrupted time-series design, with the policy date as the break point, to estimate the change in level and trend of Centre-side disbursement attributable to the rationalisation.
4. **A regression-discontinuity design at the Tamil Nadu state border.** The Madras Public Libraries Act of 1948 — and its 1979 and 2009 amendments — applies uniformly within Tamil Nadu and does not apply across its borders with Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Kerala. A geographic regression-discontinuity design at the inter-state boundary, using local reading and educational-mobility outcomes, would estimate the long-run dose-response of statutory library funding.
5. **District-level joins to SHRUG.** The state-level consolidated series presented here can be disaggregated to the district level using state DfG district-wise tables (where available) and proportional allocation against state library directorate counts (where not). Joined to the SHRUG district panel, this would permit district-level analysis of the correlation between library funding and intergenerational educational mobility, foundational learning outcomes, and labour-market integration of first-generation graduates.

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Data and Code Availability

A replication archive containing the derivation code, processed datasets, and the Quarto source for this paper is deposited in the Right to Read working-paper series’ Open Science Framework (OSF) project, with the code archived for a citable, versioned DOI on Zenodo (DOI to be assigned at public release). The processed datasets are persisted as tab-separated value files, emitted from the single canonical data layer (`spend_data.py`) by `export_series.py`, which also runs in a `--check` mode that fails if any deposited file has drifted from that layer. The file-level schema and primary input sources are set out

in the two tables below. This paper itself is released under CC-BY-NC-4.0: it may be shared, quoted, adapted, translated, and built upon, with attribution; commercial use requires a separate agreement. The deposited derived data are likewise CC-BY-NC-4.0, as are the Campaign's published charts and datasets. The analysis code is under the MIT License, Creative Commons licences being unsuited to software. Derivative and scholarly reuse is the intent: the restriction is on selling the work, not on building on it.

Table 5: Processed datasets in the replication archive. Filenames are shown in monospace; the description is the reading column.

Dataset	Rows	Coverage
National per-capita series, within-state (Series A, B, C) <code>series_national_state_only.tsv</code>	11	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
National per-capita series, consolidated (Series C*) <code>series_consolidated.tsv</code>	11	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
State-level cross-section, FY 2018-19, nominal and real <code>series_state_cross_section_2018_19.tsv</code>	31	28 States + 3 UTs (Delhi, Puducherry, J&K)
Cess-panel states, annual expenditure (lakh, nominal) <code>series_cess_states_annual.tsv</code>	7	FY 2014-15 to FY 2020-21
RRRLF total GoI grant, nominal and real per-capita <code>series_rrrlf.tsv</code>	11	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
Capital expenditure (MH 4202-04-105), nominal, real per-capita, and share <code>series_capital.tsv</code>	11	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
NAS implicit GDP deflator factors (base 2011-12) <code>series_deflator_factors.tsv</code>	11	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25

Table 6: Primary input sources for the consolidated series.

Series	Primary source	Coverage
State public-library expenditure (MH 2205-105), nominal	Kulkarni, Balaji & Dhanamjaya (2025), compiled from CAG Combined Finance and Revenue Accounts	FY 2014-15 to FY 2020-21
State expenditure (MH 2205-105) + capital (MH 4202-04-105), audited actuals	Per-State CAG Finance Accounts Vol-II (Stmts 15/16); State Finance Accounts / budget Detailed Estimates for the six jurisdictions not on the CAG portal (WB, Delhi, Puducherry, J&K, Goa, Rajasthan). All 31 States/UTs, both heads; full provenance in the replication archive	FY 2021-22 to FY 2024-25
Population denominator	MoHFW Technical Group on Population Projections (2020), Table 11 — annual July-1 projected totals	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
Implicit GDP deflator	MoSPI National Accounts Statistics, base 2011-12	FY 2014-15 to FY 2024-25
RRRLF disbursement	Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation Annual Reports, 44th–52nd editions	FY 2015-16 to FY 2023-24

The replication code is written in Python 3 and Quarto.